

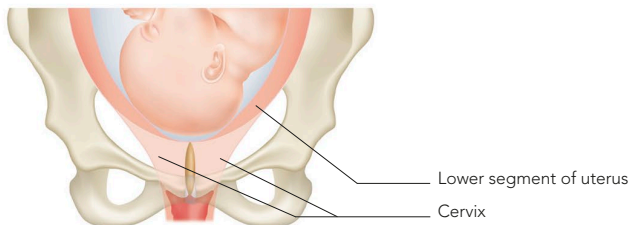
CHANGES IN THE CERVIX

The cervix is the firm band of muscle and connective tissue that forms the neck-like structure at the bottom of the uterus. In late pregnancy, it softens in readiness for childbirth. Sporadic uterine tightenings,

known as Braxton–Hicks contractions, help to thin the cervix so that it merges with the uterus's lower segment. These are usually painless and become noticeable only after the middle of pregnancy.

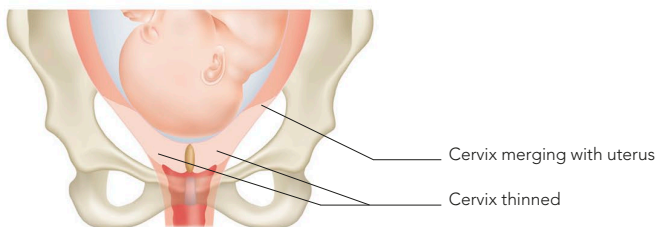
CERVIX SOFTENING

As labour nears, the cervix tissues lose their firm consistency. They become softer and more spongy, affected by natural substances in the blood called prostaglandins.



CERVIX THINNING

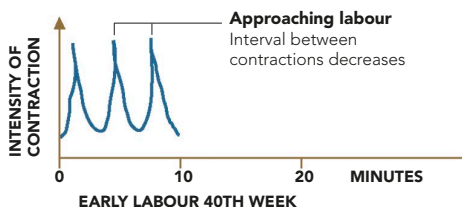
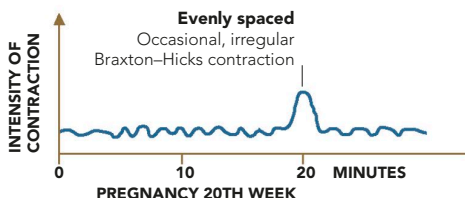
The cervix becomes wider and thinner, and merges smoothly into the uterus wall above. The process of softening and thinning is known as effacement.



CONTRACTIONS

The shortening of uterine muscles, with the eventual aim of expelling the fetus, are called contractions, which are regular and become steadily more frequent, more

painful, and longer-lasting. The main area of contraction is in the muscles of the uterine fundus (upper uterus), which stretches, causing the lower uterus and cervix to thin.



PROGRESS OF CONTRACTIONS

Gentle, partial contractions occur through much of pregnancy. True contractions begin late in pregnancy. At first, they are occasional and relatively weak. As labour intensifies, they are more frequent and last longer, putting more downward pressure on the baby.